

made of packed dirt, sand, and palmetto logs, withstood weeks of bombardment before the Confederates abandoned it and its 14 coast guns. These included a 10-in (250-mm) Columbiad that fired a 128-lb (58-kg) shell.

Many of these huge guns eventually blew up, because of flaws in casting technology. On average the South's ordnance and munitions proved the more unstable, but Union guns often exploded, too. During the 1863–64 siege of Charleston, the "Swamp Angel," a 24,000-lb (10,890 kg), 8-in (200-mm) Parrott gun, had the dubious distinction of shooting the first incendiary shells into the city; but it blew up after only 36 rounds.

Civil War sieges

In the 1862 Peninsula Campaign, General George B. McClellan dragged a massive siege train through the Virginia swamps. No fewer than 101 guns—with 20-, 30-, and even 100-pounder (9-, 14-, and 45-kg) Parrott guns and huge mortars—were erected on platforms before Yorktown, itself "protected" by a few fake cannons, or "Quaker guns," named for the pacifist Quakers.

In the Civil War, the term "siege" was often applied to any grinding struggle involving fortified positions—Atlanta and Petersburg among them. These battles borrowed many elements of traditional sieges, including mining, countermining, labyrinths of enclosed entrenchments, and the often commanding use of heavy artillery.

Sherman had been at Vicksburg, but he once declared, "I'm too impatient for a siege." In 1864, when he attacked Atlanta, the city was ringed with fortifications, but most of the fighting took the form of battles of maneuver around its outskirts. Regular approaches were never attempted, although Sherman did bring up four 4.5-in (114-mm) rifled guns that lobbed 30-lb (13.6-kg) shells into the city to supplement his field artillery.